Tuticorin they were met by a launch belonging to Madura and Company which cost Rs 2 per passenger.[81] The company's clerks also made arrangements to collect and pick up the luggage on the deck. Breakfast and refreshments were arranged through Bois Bros, BI's Colombo agents.[82]

BI tied up with South Indian Railway to enable seamless travel and switchover for passengers and cargo, giving it a clear advantage over its rivals.[83] Cargo was transferred by sailing boats with a capacity to carry up to 20 tons. During the period of our study, these boats charged about Rs 15 per trip.[84] The relationship between South Indian Railway and BI was smooth, further adding to the strength of the former.[85] An advertisement issued by the railway company listed nine elaborate points for the Tuticorin–Colombo route.[86] A through ticket for all BI voyages anywhere from Europe and Australia could be purchased at all railway counters. Some of the services pertained more specifically to Tuticorin and Colombo. 'The Boat Mail', of SIR 'runs direct to the Pier to the B.I.S.N. Co.'s Steamer Steam Launch', a service that obviated the inconvenience of changing from the train to a carriage.[87]

South Indian Railway too did not lag behind in providing services. Value-added services included waiting accommodation for 'ladies and gentlemen'. Refreshments were served by the fashionable Spencer and Company. The butler usually had some newspapers—only European-owned papers such as the *Madras Mail* and not *The Hindu*; there was no question of any Tamil periodicals—apart from some travellers' requisites. The train was well-stocked with ice and aerated water but in case the Colombo steamer arrived late, Spencer's were happy to serve breakfast on the train.[88] During the tourist season, breakfast could be had on the train itself while at other times it was provided in the refreshment room. A bogie carriage was also arranged between Tuticorin and Erode 'with one first, two 2nd class and one servant's compartments'. Taking this train meant that there was no need to change at Trichirappalli.[89]

It was in such a port town that the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company set shop.